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Conflicting Interpretations of Christian Pacifism

Michael G. Cartwright

THOUGH HE DISCUSSES Christian nonviolence with scholarly care, Ted Koontz remains a passionately committed Christian. By insisting that the questions nonviolent Christians ask about the ethics of war and peace are different from the questions asked by those who approach the topic from other directions, he reminds us of the importance of religious convictions, or the absence of such convictions, in shaping how we understand war/peace ethics.¹ Moreover, his forthrightness in articulating the conceptions of truth and power that arise from the tradition of Christian pacifism, and especially from the practices of Christian worship, opens the way for a fuller assessment of the possibilities and limits of conversation between ethical traditions.

Koontz's chapter also evokes a number of critical questions, however. How adequate is the typology of Christian nonviolence he presents? Which conceptions of war and peace are omitted from his discussion? Given the differences he identifies between "the house of fear" and "the house of love," has Koontz exaggerated the contrast between Christian nonviolence and just war thinking? And if so, what are the implications of this exaggeration for assessing the particular understanding of truth and power he wishes to defend? Finally, might not his portrayal of the conversation between Christian pacifists and others distort, and thereby impede, this conversation?

No matter how we answer questions like these, Koontz has brought into view a set of concerns that, though not often examined in comparative ethics, are essential to understanding the moral logic of Christian nonviolence.

INTERPRETING TYPOLOGIES OF WAR/PEACE ETHICS

Koontz acknowledges that his chapter offers no more than "an interpretation" of Christian nonviolence. There are good reasons for such hermeneutical modesty. Christian ethicists—pacifist and nonpacifist—have struggled for many years with a broad array of hermeneutical issues,² and there remain significant and unresolved disagreements between the various forms of pacifism, abolitionism, and nonviolent resistance, as well as

opposition to arguments outside the family of Christian nonviolence. Christian pacifists today have no choice but to take seriously the fact that “peacemaking” has become a kind of linguistic umbrella under which a diversity of theological approaches now collect. Nor can they ignore the fact that many nonpacifists regard their views as at best quaint and at worst dangerous.

Calling attention to the hermeneutic self-consciousness of Koontz’s chapter opens the way toward assessing the other, more significant, interpretive issues he raises. To begin with, we need to examine the typology on which he relies. Some typologies are designed to characterize precisely each identified position,³ others to identify “family resemblances” linking an unresolved diversity of positions. Koontz’s typology is of the latter sort, though he is concerned to avoid misrepresenting the different positions that cluster under the label “Christian nonviolence.” Nevertheless, how we define alternative types of ethical thinking about war and peace can significantly structure the ensuing conversation. Different typologies of pacifism project different conversations about war and peace.

If the conversation is framed as one between just war thinking and Christian pacifism, it is likely to proceed with advocates for just war focusing attention on Christian pacifists—as if *they* were the problem—while neglecting the challenge posed by other kinds of thinking about war and peace, such as “holy war” thinking, political realism, and Rambo-style militarism. But one can also frame the war/peace conversation in terms of a quite different typology, one designed to clarify the areas of theological agreement and disagreement that exist within a given tradition of Christian nonviolence.⁴ In the former case, the conversation will be one that is focused on the responsibilities of citizen-leaders in relation to the state. In the latter, the typology points toward a conversation in which the identification of different types of peace theology is preliminary to developing a theological consensus (within the religious tradition) that can, in turn, lead to more articulate ways of representing Christian pacifism in ecumenical and political contexts.

In short, the usefulness of a typology of the ethics of war and peace depends upon which conversation is in view and which kind of conflict of interpretations is being assessed. It is a mistake to assume that there is one principle of classification that will sort everything out for us. The interpretive conflicts internal to particular traditions of moral thinking generate one kind of moral argumentation and disputation; conflicts between ethical traditions generate another. For this reason, Koontz’s discussion, which seeks to represent Christian nonviolence in a book concerned with dialogue between different perspectives, is less nuanced, theologically speaking, than were he to address the topic in the context of a debate about Mennonite peace theologies. But the conversation with other viewpoints implicit in Koontz’s chapter has its own coherence insofar as it allows for

honest disagreements over how to characterize the similarities and differences between perspectives.

Given his assignment, it is hardly an accident that Koontz has structured the conversation as he has. The threefold typology of Christian nonviolent perspectives—pacifism, abolitionism, and nonviolent resistance—serves several purposes in his argument. First, he uses it to describe an array of approaches, some explicitly grounded in theological conceptions and others more pragmatically or politically grounded. He does not attempt to identify conceptual differences within an array of historical categories. Instead, the typology merely describes a number of positions that have taken shape in relation to one another. In doing so, it hides important differences. In the case of abolitionism, for example, Koontz's formulation mixes two conceptually distinct approaches, one represented by what might be called "world order visionaries" like Erasmus, the other by the isolationist abolitionism of many liberal Protestant pacifists during the 1920s and 1930s. The moral arguments relied upon in each case are logically separable, however much these approaches may resemble each other in other ways.

Second, Koontz explicates the theological context of a single position within this typology—what he calls "Christian pacifism." But the typology permits him to include all three types of Christian nonviolence in answering the topic-related questions—questions that are particularly awkward to address from within the theologically grounded perspective of Christian pacifism.

It is important to be clear about what Koontz is and is not doing with his typology of Christian nonviolence in relation to his larger argumentative strategy. He does not use it to present certain categories as universally applicable and thus to delegitimize all forms of pacifism as "irresponsible." What he is doing is more nearly the opposite of such a strategy. Implicit in his chapter, however, and coinciding with his use of the typology, is a bid for respect from various interlocutors whom he identifies in relation to the questions around which this book is constructed. By arguing that if one wants to understand why some people are Christian pacifists, one must enter their world and on their own terms, Koontz appeals to his audience to set aside their assumption that pacifists are irrelevant or dangerous characters. Here we see him engaging in a subtle form of apologetic argument. In effect, Koontz is saying to his readers: "I want you to understand why it is that you cannot understand what I am talking about."

MUST ONE BE A PACIFIST TO UNDERSTAND PACIFIST ARGUMENTS?

Had the conversation in which Koontz finds himself been structured by a different set of questions, he might not have felt the need to employ this kind of indirect apologetic. But the questions the contributors to this volume were asked to address do not lend themselves to providing a "thick

description” of his own theologically based pacifism. Accordingly, Koontz prefaces his discussion of these questions with a brief commentary on the significance of the kinds of question we permit to guide our thinking about the issues of war and peace. And he is right to do so, because, too often, the discussion of war and peace is conducted without awareness of how the questions we ask provide an overriding authority for some modes of ethical inquiry while they reject others. There is, for example, a tendency to assume that “consequentialist” questions are somehow definitive, and that moral viewpoints that reject consequentialist reasoning are, for that reason, defective.

But it is one thing to contest the adequacy of the questions being asked, and quite another to present the case for Christian nonviolence in a way that implies that one must be a pacifist to understand pacifist arguments. In this respect, Koontz appears to have overstated the incommensurability, philosophically speaking, of pacifist and nonpacifist conceptions of peace. It is unfortunate that he largely ignores the historical character of those conceptions of war and peace that are part of the wider family of Christian nonviolence, because the very shape of the conversation in which these conceptions have emerged has changed. To be precise, several changes have occurred during the past century in the way moral arguments about war and peace are engaged—changes in moral thinking and social analysis that also inform Koontz’s own argument. Though no single factor has determined these changes, there is a sense in which Christian pacifists have repeatedly had to face interpretations of their stance that are unfavorable, even if not always tendentious. Nowhere is this more true than in the North American context, where Christian nonviolence is frequently seen as irresponsible unless its advocates assent to the interpretation of their conception of peace as apolitical.

Let us consider an example. On the eve of the Second World War, Reinhold Niebuhr provided an influential argument for “Why the Christian Church Is Not Pacifist.”⁵ As John Howard Yoder has noted, the impact of Niebuhr’s argument that nonviolence is morally and politically irresponsible can be illustrated in the ways that Christian pacifists began to articulate their position at mid-century. Many Christian pacifists simply accepted the Niebuhrian distinctions between nonresistance and nonviolence without raising questions about the theoretical basis of such classifications. Although Niebuhr’s conception of politics and its corollary dichotomy between “moral man and immoral society” have been criticized, theologically as well as politically, his “Christian realism” remains potent enough to inform a number of recent attacks upon Christian pacifists.⁶

Those Christian pacifists who have contested Niebuhrian-style polemics have shifted the burden of proof back to those in the just war and realist

camps who characterize Christian nonviolence as irresponsible. Yoder, for example, has avoided conceding the authority of just war reasoning, and instead has used particular wars to test the adequacy of the idea of the “justifiability” of warring.⁷ Others have adopted what might be called a “contrarian” approach, one that presumes that just war arguments mask ends other than that of restoring peace and that such arguments reflect an unannounced political agenda. This approach is contrarian, not only because of the combative way it rejects the legitimacy of just war arguments, but also because it questions the very framework within which the discussion of war and peace proceeds.

This contrarian tendency has been particularly noticeable in the wake of the 1991 Persian Gulf War. Stanley Hauerwas’s “Whose Justice? Which Peace?” is illustrative.⁸ Dissenting from the just war premises of the other essays on the morality of the Gulf War in the collection in which his appears, Hauerwas argues that “there is much more to the question of the moral evaluation of war than the question of whether a war conforms to just war criteria” and calls attention to assumptions that have dictated what are “widely regarded as the relevant questions for assessing the morality of the Gulf War.” Having raised the issue of meta-ethical criteria, he goes on to argue that

it makes all the difference who is asking questions about the “justice” of war and for what reasons. When questions of who and why are ignored, the history that has shaped just war reflection as well as the conflicting histories of the Gulf War are assumed irrelevant.

The Gulf War was fought by those for whom it was actually a kind of holy war, but who “found it useful to justify it on just war grounds.”⁹

Though Koontz avoids Hauerwas’s combative tone, he, too, adopts a contrarian strategy. Both argue that Christian identity is not only important for grasping the moral significance of Christian nonviolence, but further, that it is necessary for understanding. At their best, these arguments invite nonpacifist readers to consider the possibility that “the emperor has no clothes,” but they also say, “I want you to understand why you cannot understand me.” Though provocative, this stance does not invite further conversation—unless the nonpacifist reader is already disposed to convert to this position! Arguably, then, the contrarian style of argument can be taken to suggest that there is no reason for nonpacifists to engage in conversation with Christian nonviolence. By assuming antipathy on the part of the conversational partner, the contrarian overstates the incommensurability of moral arguments and thereby (prematurely) suggests that various kinds of dialogue, which may or may not develop, will *not* occur.

Oddly enough, Koontz’s rhetoric stresses incommensurability while it appears to offer his readers a hermeneutical key to unlock the mystery that

lies at the heart of Christian pacifism. Though he invites conversation to explore its disagreements with other viewpoints, Koontz severely limits that conversation by offering an account of Christian pacifism that itself presumes an ethical dualism based upon a “two kingdoms” political ethic. His argument differs from Hauerwas’s inasmuch as Koontz identifies with the reader’s incredulity instead of indicting the opponent’s integrity. At the same time, Koontz goes beyond inviting the reader to consider the possibility that “the emperor has no clothes” to offer a theological assessment of the difference between those who inhabit the “house of love” (Christian pacifists) and those who dwell in the “house of fear” (realists and just warriors).

Nowhere is this tension between inviting conversation and rejecting it more prominent than in his sermon, “Blessed Be the King.” The sermon provides outsiders with a glimpse of the theological conceptions underlying Christian pacifist discourse by illuminating the difference between what (from a Christian point of view) is the “false hope” that sees political and social progress narrowly in terms of the application of the power of the state, and what is an authentically *Christian* hope that condemns as false and even idolatrous conceptions of power that presume to eliminate the necessity of suffering.

When Koontz turns to the topic-related questions, it is clear that the sermon not only has served the purpose of elucidating the theological warrants that underlie Christian pacifist claims about war and peace, but also has revealed the ideological conflicts that make it difficult for these claims to be registered as politically significant. For, he argues, the claim of “necessity” makes sense only in relation to ends that are deemed more important than keeping one’s moral commitments. Unlike the political realist—or indeed, anyone else holding a consequentialist ethic—the Christian pacifist is free of the necessity of worrying about what is in God’s hands, free from the burden of making history come out right. We can have no duty to “help God out” by violating God’s moral standards.

In this context, Koontz’s use of Henri Nouwen’s image of inhabitants of the “house of fear” versus those of the “house of love” provocatively juxtaposes alternative worldviews. But it is not obvious that the contrast between the “house of love” and the “house of fear” is as sharp as this would imply. It may be true that “fearful questions never lead to love-filled answers,” but there are many kinds of “fearful questions,” and not all such questions are necessarily prompted by the same kinds of fear. To refine the image of the two houses, then, we might agree that not all rooms in the house of fear are equally well-furnished, morally speaking. Whatever may be said about the differences between just war and pacifism, for example, in contrast to *realpolitik* or “the blank check,” just warriors and pacifists agree that the burden of proof is upon those who choose war. Both reject

the primacy of consequentialist reasoning in making political as well as personal decisions. By putting political realism and just war thinking in the same house, Koontz exaggerates the moral differences that separate natural law and Christian pacifism while he neglects the differences between natural law and political realism. Because Koontz's image of the two houses exaggerates the contrast between pacifist and anticonsequentialist moral outlooks, it arbitrarily limits the possibilities for conversation between their adherents.

CONFLICTING INTERPRETATIONS OF CHRISTIAN NONVIOLENCE

The bold contrast that Koontz draws between those who have converted to the Christian position and those who have not reflects a broader conception of dualist ethics, one that sharply distinguishes the moral obligations of the Church from those of the (unconverted) world. According to the dualist conception, Koontz argues, those "committed to the way of Christ" are expected to live differently from those in "the world." The dualist conception therefore leaves open the possibility of a certain "quasi-legitimate" justification for war, provided it is chosen and waged not by Christians but by the state. This view of the "higher responsibility" of Christians has its origins in another ongoing conflict of interpretations within a number of Protestant traditions. As Koontz observes, the conflict arises out of two closely related scriptural passages, St. Paul's Letter to the Romans 12:9–21 and 13:1–7, and is dramatically evident in the 1527 Schleithem Confession: "The sword is an ordering of God outside the perfection of Christ. It punishes and kills the wicked and protects the Good."

According to some historians of Christianity, the idea that there are different expectations for those who are part of the covenant of Christianity and those "outside the perfection of Christ" crystallized only at Schleithem in 1527; others hold that the idea emerged long before this time. But even the "Schleithem interpretation" has not always been articulated with the same political assumptions in mind, either by Christian pacifists in the Anabaptist-Mennonite tradition or by those in the broader tradition of Protestant Christianity. Just as not all American Mennonites have articulated their peace witness within the rhetoric of "nonresistance"—some nineteenth-century Mennonites preferred the older vocabulary of "defenseless" (*wehrlos*) witness, for example—not all Christian pacifists have felt it necessary to adopt ethical dualism as part of the rationale for their Christian pacifist stance.

Christian pacifists both inside and outside the Anabaptist tradition who have adopted some version of ethical dualism with respect to the state often cite the Schleithem formulation as if it were applicable to every

situation of pacifist engagement with the state. But Yoder has cautioned Christian pacifists about the conceptual error of “solidifying the dualism” of the Schleithem statement, arguing that the Schleithem formulation should not be treated as if it were a “systematic or comprehensive political ethic.”¹⁰ On the contrary, the Schleithem formulation represents a “tense missionary dualism” that became necessary in a situation marked by a refusal to tolerate the witness of Anabaptists in the world in which they found themselves at the time. And, as Yoder goes on to argue elsewhere, this particular response needs to be seen in light of the “variety of logically possible positions which could be taken on the question of the sword in the context of the Reformation debates.”¹¹

When this kind of historical analysis is performed, it becomes clear that the “two kingdoms” dualism later generations have articulated in relation to the Schleithem Confession is not the only kind of response consistent with the Christian Bible. The dualistic interpretation also overlooks some of the most salient features of the political situation the Anabaptists who gathered at Schleithem were facing. An excessive focus on Schleithem can distort the conversation that Christian pacifists have with nonpacifists precisely to the degree that it assumes that the Christian witness to the state always takes shape within one kind of conversation. But this is not the case, as the existence of other kinds of Christian nonviolence demonstrates.

The writings of James Douglass, a Catholic lay theologian and anti-nuclear peace activist, offer a version of Christian nonviolence that is not structured by ethical dualism and that therefore illustrates wider possibilities for conversation between Christian nonviolence and the nonpacifist traditions. Douglass’s reflections on peace grow out of his training in natural law and his subsequent conviction that the prospect of nuclear war has made warfare pointless as a mode of settling differences. Douglass therefore bases his argument in *The Non-Violent Cross* in part on just war grounds. But he also anchors it in the more elastic conception of peace found in the papal encyclical *Pacem in terris* of John XXIII, which Douglass admires for its pervasive, though admittedly undefined, conception of nonviolence. As he notes, though the encyclical is addressed to the Church, it is also “addressed far beyond the visible church,” that is, to the larger world it may eventually help to transform.¹² Douglass acknowledges the many criticisms of *Pacem in terris*, including those of Protestant moralists like Reinhold Niebuhr, but he resists Niebuhr’s complaint that the encyclical lacks realism, and he even provides natural law arguments for what he sees as a coming “revolution of peace” through Gandhian nonviolence.

In retrospect, Douglass’s arguments for the “transformation of man” and the “revolution of peace” seem careless and overstated. They do, however, provide an interesting specimen of a conception of Christian non-

violence that is not determined by the kind of ethical dualism to which Koontz is committed. For though Douglass's chapter on "Christians and the State" discusses the issues presented by Romans 13:1–7, it is clear that his conception of peace is not determined by the interpretation of this passage. There are two reasons why this is the case. First, Douglass sharply distinguishes between applying such a passage in Paul's time and the various "two kingdoms" interpretations of the passage articulated by Protestants like Martin Luther. Second, following Karl Rahner, he contends that the Church can be both catholic and in diaspora at the same time. Therefore, the Church's sphere of peacemaking is not confined to the community of belief, but takes the form of a "decisive confrontation" with the world in which the Church embodies the "cross of suffering redemptive love." In the end, then,

there can be no ethical justification even for the governing authorities bearing the sword, because the only valid ethic is that revealed by Christ in the Gospel, a love that does no wrong to a neighbor.¹³

Thus, though tension between the peace of the Christian community and the so-called peace of the world continues, it is a mistake to attribute to St. Paul a "responsibility ethic" based on Romans 13:1–7.

Most observers would agree that Douglass's conception of peacemaking is not representative of contemporary Catholic thinking on war and peace. This may be more true of American Catholicism than of the Vatican itself, however. According to a 1992 editorial in *La civiltà Cattolica*, the Jesuit magazine published in Rome, the transformation of warfare in the modern era "obliges us to consider arguments for war from a completely new perspective." The editorial argues that Roman Catholic thinking on the ethics of war and peace has shifted significantly during the course of the century. The Catholic Church has formally condemned war in four important documents between 1920 and 1991. More and more, the Church "has absolutely condemned war and moved beyond the old arguments for the 'just war' or 'holy war' in defense of the faith," and "this attitude indicates an advance in Christian conscience regarding the absolute immunity of war." The editorial discusses the 1991 Persian Gulf War as the principal example of the way an "ideology of war" has co-opted just war theory in the midst of the transformation of modern warfare. The author concludes:

The theory of the just war is indefensible and has been abandoned. In reality—with the sole exception of a purely defensive war against acts of aggression—we can say that there are no "just wars" and there is no "right" to wage war.

Accordingly, Roman Catholics are called upon to "unmask" warmaking, even as they engage in positive efforts to make peace between individuals and nations.¹⁴

Like Douglass's argument in *The Non-Violent Cross*, that put forward in *La civiltà Cattolica* posits no ethical dualism. The Church's pastoral concern is addressed not only to its own members but also to non-Christian citizens and governments, for whom it is presented as normative, on natural law grounds. In this respect, the editorial remains squarely within the mainstream of Roman Catholic moral theology. But by historicizing the debate about the justifiability of war and thereby going beyond secular interpretations of just war thinking, the editorial reasserts a broadly and distinctively Christian way of thinking about the ethics of war and peace. Clearly, both these examples of Catholic revisionism converge with the concerns of Christian pacifism, even though they are argued from within a version of natural law ethics. Both share Koontz's wish to articulate an ethic of peace that does not rest on worldly conceptions of truth and power, but they do not share Koontz's ethical dualism. This dualism disallows the possibility, yet to be fully explored, of a convergence between pacifism and natural law.

KINGSHIP AND MARTYRDOM

These disputes about ethical dualism raise further questions about the alternative conceptions of truth and power implicit in Koontz's treatment of the "kingship" of Christ in his Palm Sunday sermon. Recall that, in this sermon, Koontz poses a question to his congregation: "How can we overcome fear, accept the possibility of the cross, live lives which are, paradoxically, both fully vulnerable, and wonderfully powerful?" The answer he offers is specified in terms of discovering the reality of the kingship of Christ:

I believe that the key lies in really seeing, in really *believing*, that Jesus is King. Though we take for granted the Kingship of Jesus and, unlike the people of his time, understand that his Kingship is radically different from that of worldly kings, I wonder if we *really* understand, I wonder if we *really* believe.

As we have already noted, Koontz here attempts to identify the heart of the mystery of Christian pacifism for his readers while he also stresses the ultimate difference between those who "really believe" and those who do not.

The Acts of the Apostles suggest that the earliest Christian communities really did believe that Jesus Christ was their king (Hebrew "messiah"). Christians were characterized by the officials of the Roman empire as those "who have turned the world upside down . . . acting against the decrees of Caesar, saying there is another king, King Jesus" (Acts 17:6, 7). The early Christians were viewed with suspicion precisely because their witness (Greek *martyria*) called into question the political conceptions of truth and power upon which the Roman empire was built. Christian witness was

often mistaken for atheism by those who did not recognize the King to whom they bore witness.

The example of Dirk Willems, the Dutch martyr, which Koontz discusses at two points in his chapter, also illustrates the alternative conceptions of truth and power toward which Koontz gestures. From the perspective of natural law, Willems's martyrdom seems unnecessarily heroic, an act of supererogation, and therefore not the kind of thing that should be regarded as a duty for everyone.¹⁵ But his act becomes morally significant when placed in the context of a Christian understanding of the conduct required of those who bear witness to "King Jesus"—an understanding that places the meaning of history *not* in the progression of political actions, narrowly understood, but in the acts of God in the world in behalf of God's people, the Church.

But even more important than the striking difference in assessments evoked by this particular example of martyrdom is the overriding question of the relationship between conceptions of war and peace and conceptions of truth. As Koontz notes at the end of his essay, Dirk Willems's martyrdom cannot be detached from the broader framework of sixteenth-century theological disputes, as these disputes were handled in the political sphere. As he pointedly observes, Willems's death "was part of a 'debate' over religious truth" in a society in which people believed that truth could be discovered through torture. Pushing his point even further, Koontz asserts that with regard to how we go about settling questions of right between nations, we have hardly progressed beyond this level.

Koontz also calls attention to the presumptions about power in the conflict of truth claims between the "defenders of civilization" and "barbarians." His eloquent homiletic conclusion demonstrates the difference that is made when one's analysis of human conflict is framed by the theological and historical vision of "the power of the cross through which Jesus disarmed the principalities and the powers." But when Koontz concludes dramatically that the barbarians are not "out there," that "we are the barbarians," he seems to have lost sight of the difference he previously posited between those who really believe and those who do not. If we are all barbarians, it would appear that even those who inhabit the "house of love" are possessed by fear.

This point brings us back to nonpacifist suspicions about the legitimacy of conceptions of truth and power embedded in the claims of Christian nonviolence. The presence of such suspicions cannot help but have implications for conversations between Christian pacifists and those whose thinking about war and peace is shaped by other ethical traditions. Yet, as different as Koontz's conceptions of truth and power are from those implicitly or explicitly present elsewhere in this volume, there is no reason to believe that the other contributors (or the readers of this book) can-

not grasp the point Koontz is making in his sermon. Whether they will be persuaded to convert to Christianity (or to Christian pacifism) is another question! The point, however, is not to suggest that such an illustration must persuade. It is enough merely to show that the moral action embodied in Dirk Willems's martyrdom can be made intelligible. In this as in other matters, advocates of Christian nonviolence have little choice but to be patient as well as persistent in offering their nonviolent witness to the state.

CONVERSATION DESPITE INTERPRETIVE CONFLICT

It is characteristic of the Christian pacifist understanding of itself that it should seek conversation with "the world" for the purpose of converting the world to the way of Christ. Once this purpose is understood, we are in a better position to assess the claim that pacifist and nonpacifist arguments are incommensurable.

As we have already observed, one of the conceptual tensions at the heart of Koontz's chapter is the relationship between the ideas of truth and power as these are understood within "the house of love" and "the house of fear." Here it may help to call attention to the practical and theological importance of the relationship between the *evangelical* practice of "speaking truth to power" as a way of engaging the world nonviolently, and the *ecclesial* practice of peacemaking between Christians, a practice identified in the writings of sixteenth-century radical reformation as "The Rule of Christ." Explicating these practices in relation to one another will help us see how the conversation between Christian pacifists and others might be structured in a way that escapes Koontz's overly hermeneutical contrast.

Most adherents to the tradition of Christian nonviolence agree that "speaking truth to power" is an integral part of Christian witness to the state. But there is disagreement about whether Christians can ever legitimize particular instances of violence by the state. Christians, it sometimes urged, should focus their efforts on "living at peace with all people" insofar as this is possible (and here, as in so many things, we have to confront the limits of our moral imaginations), leaving vengeance as well as "making history come out right" in the hands of God (Rom. 12:9–21). In this respect, I would agree with Yoder's rather sparse, untheorized account of Christian witness to the state, which assumes that there is no such thing as "the state" *per se*.¹⁶ There are simply states as we encounter them in particular historical situations. Just as we do not have to regard the Church's situation before the world to be, in all cases, like that presumed by the Schleithem Confession, so we are not stuck with the "worldly authorities" described in Romans 13:1–7 or, for that matter, with "the beast" of Revelation 13:1–18.

Christian engagement with political authority must allow for other possibilities, including the possibility (however unlikely it may be in most instances) that the principalities and powers might join in acknowledging the Lordship of Jesus Christ and alter their practices accordingly. After all, according to the vision of the end of history described in Revelation 5:1–14, the procession of Christian worship will ultimately include every creature on earth. Christian pacifists should therefore not underestimate the political power of celebrating the Lordship of Christ. After all, this is the truth to which a story like that of Dirk Willems's attests.

Meanwhile, Christian pacifists have more than enough to do making a different kind of peace, one structured by a different set of questions, than the kind of peace sought by most governments most of the time. Here, too, I would join with Yoder in arguing that it is possible to “translate” or render intelligible “before the eyes of the watching world” specifically Christian conceptions of peace by focusing on particular practices.

Space permits only one illustration of how this works. The early Anabaptists received their name because they rebaptized people as an act of resistance to the Constantinian alliance between Church and State. But it is arguably the practice of “the Rule of Christ” that was more provocative politically because it located the source of authority in God's will as manifested in the practices of the community of Christian believers rather than in those of the “tax collector.” “The Rule of Christ” is also known as “binding and loosing,” after Matthew 18:15–20:

If another member of the church sins against you, go and point out the fault when the two of you are alone. If the member listens to you, you have regained that one. But if you are not listened to, take one or two others along with you, so that every word may be confirmed by the evidence of two or three witnesses. If the member refuses to listen to them, tell it to the church; and if the offender refuses to listen even to the church, let such a one be to you as a Gentile and a tax collector. Truly I tell you, whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven. Again, truly I tell you, if two of you agree on earth about anything you ask, it will be done for you by my Father in heaven. For where two or three are gathered in my name, I am there among them.

These practices concretely embodied a different kind of political power and a different kind of truth-telling, both of which were intelligible only in relation to the life, ministry, death, and resurrection of Jesus.

The confidence of Christian pacifists in the face of religious repression, including the implied or actual threat of martyrdom, is perhaps best summed up in the sixteenth-century epigram “Truth is unkillable.”¹⁷ The immediate context of at least one famous use of this provocative declaration was an explication in the 1520s by Balthasar Hubmaier of “binding

and loosing” as a practice of dialogue and discipline, centered in a congregation of Christians, that includes the possibility both of forgiveness and absolution (where repentance is present) and of excommunication (where there is no repentance).¹⁸ This practice, which over time has taken several different shapes, is central to the tradition of Christian discipleship identified with the Anabaptists and with the Mennonite Church in particular.

More recently, Stanley Hauerwas has called attention to the moral significance of the ecclesial virtue of “peacemaking” described in Matthew 18:15–22. As the following passage suggests, this practice of peacemaking projects conceptions of truth and power that differ dramatically from those presupposed by nonpacifists:

If peacemaking as a virtue is intrinsic to the nature of the church, what are we to say of those outside the church? First, I think we must say that it is the task of the church to confront and challenge the false peace of the world which is too often built on power more than truth. To challenge the world’s sense of peace may well be dangerous, because often when sham peace is exposed it threatens to become more violent. The church, however, cannot be less truthful with the world than it is expected to be with itself. If we are less truthful we have no peace to offer to the world.

Secondly, Christians are prohibited from ever despairing of the peace possible in the world. We know that as God’s creatures we are not naturally violent nor are our institutions unavoidably violent. As God’s people we have been created for peace. Rather, what we must do is to help the world find the habits of peace whose absence so often makes violence seem like the only alternative. Peacemaking as a virtue is an act of imagination built on long habits of the resolution of differences. The great problem in the world is that our imagination has been stilled, since it has not made a practice of confronting wrongs so that violence might be avoided. In truth, we must say that the church has too often failed the world by its failure to witness in our own life the kind of conflict necessary to be a community of peace. Without an example of a peacemaking community, the world has no alternative but to use violence as a means to settle disputes.¹⁹

Hauerwas’s way of making the point is useful for spelling out another set of conceptual problems embedded in Koontz’s ethical dualism. First, whatever we may make of various attempts to provide empirical assessments of human disorder, theologically speaking, Christians have a stake in arguing that human beings are not naturally violent. Accordingly, while we recognize the “fallenness” of the world, we must nevertheless call the world to be that which God has created it to be, and part of what it means to communicate this more positive assessment of “the world as it was created to be” is to avoid resigning ourselves to the “fallenness” of the world.

Second, had Koontz paid even more attention than he does to the *prac-*

tices of peacemaking, he would not have overstated the hermeneutical contrast between Christian pacifism and other ethical perspectives. For political practices like “the rule of Christ” (“binding and loosing”) can provide, as Yoder puts it, “analogies for conflict resolution, alternatives to litigation, and alternative perspectives on ‘corrections.’”²⁰ In other words, the kind of ecclesial practice described in Matthew 18:15–20 can “function as a paradigm for ways in which other social groups may operate. . . . People who do not share the faith or join the community can learn from them.”²¹

Finally, as Hauerwas suggests, the absence of alternative forms of peacemaking helps to explain why many people “in the world” find the Christian pacifist understanding of war/peace ethics implausible. In the end, conceptions of war and peace can only be fully explicated in relation to the practices that embody these conceptions. From a Christian pacifist perspective, the resolution of interpretive conflicts is ultimately subject to the persuasion that may or may not occur when Christian pacifists encounter those who understand the ethics of war and peace differently. Following Hauerwas’s argument about the political significance of the practice of peacemaking, the best way to begin the conversation with the adherents of nonpacifist traditions as they encounter Christian pacifists may be to point to practices like “the rule of Christ.” If in the process these other traditions are able to understand the connection between this practice and the theological claim that the Lordship of Jesus Christ applies not only over the Church but over “the principalities and powers,” and over history itself, then we will have succeeded in starting a conversation about Christian peacemaking in the midst of Christian pacifism’s ongoing conflict of interpretations.²²

NOTES

1. The best discussion of the ethical significance of religious convictions is James William McClendon, Jr. and James M. Smith, *Convictions: Defusing Religious Relativism*, rev. ed. (Valley Forge, PA: Trinity Press International, 1994).

2. Awareness of the importance of interpretive issues occurs as early as Reinhold Niebuhr’s *An Interpretation of Christians Ethics* (New York: Harper and Brothers, 1935). For discussion of the many ways in which the question of hermeneutics haunts contemporary Christian ethics, see William B. Schweiker’s essay, “Interpretation, Teaching and American Theological Ethics,” *Annual of the Society of Christian Ethics* 1990 (Washington, DC: Georgetown University Press, 1990), 284.

3. See, for example, John Howard Yoder, *Nevertheless: Varieties of Religious Pacifism* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1971; rev. ed. 1992).

4. See, for example, the collection of articles in *Mennonite Peace Theology: A Panorama of Types*, edited by John Richard Burkholder and Barbara Nelson Gingrich and available from the Mennonite Central Committee Peace Office in Washington, DC.

5. See the first essay in Reinhold Niebuhr's *Christianity and Power Politics* (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1940), 1–32.

6. The most recent of these Niebuhrian attacks on Christian pacifism is Guenter Lewy's *Peace and Revolution: The Moral Crisis of American Pacifism* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1988).

7. See, for example, Yoder's *When War Is Unjust: Being Honest in Just War Thinking* (Minneapolis: Augsburg, 1984), and his "Just War Tradition: Is It Credible?" in *Christian Century* 108 (13 Mar. 1991), 295.

8. Stanley Hauerwas, "Whose Justice? Which Peace?" in David DeCosse, ed., *But Was It Just?* (New York: Bantam Doubleday Dell, 1992), 83–105.

9. Hauerwas, "Whose Justice? Which Peace?" 83, 84, 88.

10. John Howard Yoder, *Christian Attitudes to War, Peace and Revolution: A Companion to Bainton* (Elkhart, IN: Associated Mennonite Biblical Seminaries, 1983), 193.

11. See Yoder's "Anabaptism and the Sword Revisited: Systematic Historiography and Undogmatic Nonresistance," *Zeitschrift für Kirchengeschichte* 85 (1974), 270–83. I am indebted to John Richard Burkholder for calling this comment to my attention. See Burkholder's "Mennonite Peace Theology: Reconnaissance and Exploration," *Conrad Grebel Review* 10 (1992), 264, esp. n. 13.

12. James W. Douglass, *The Non-Violent Cross: A Theology of Revolution and Peace* (London: Macmillan, 1966), 83.

13. Douglass, *Non-Violent Cross*, 205, 207.

14. An English translation of "Modern War and the Christian Conscience," originally published in *La civiltà Cattolica*, has been published in DeCosse, *But Was It Just?*. The quoted passages are from pages 118, 121, and 123 of this edition. Although the editorials published in *La civiltà Cattolica* are not official statements of the Vatican, they are reviewed by the Vatican Secretariat of State. According to the Rev. GianPaolo Salvini, editorial director of this journal, the article is "not contrary to the mind of the Vatican."

15. Although realists usually regard religious martyrdom as politically irrelevant, on occasion the martyr may be seen as dangerous. In 1993, for example, an exhibit of martyrs' stories scheduled to open at the Smithsonian Institution in Washington, DC, was abruptly cancelled. The reason? According to museum officials, the public display "threatened national security." The proposed exhibit was to have included life-size illustrations made from surviving copperplate etchings from the 1685 edition of *The Martyrs Mirror of the Defenseless Christians*, among them a picture of Dirk Willems. For an account of the controversy, see Tom Price, "Mennonites Off the Wall," *Christian Century* (14–21 Jul. 1993), 200.

16. John H. Yoder, *The Christian Witness to the State* (Newton, KS: Faith and Life Press, 1964), 78, esp. n. 5.

17. For a discussion of the background of this epigram (*Die Wahrheit ist untödlich*) and a justification of the way it has been translated, see John H. Yoder and Wayne Pipkin, *Balthasar Hubmaier, Theologian of Anabaptism* (Scottsdale, PA: Herald Press, 1989), 76–77 n. 10.

18. Balthasar Hubmaier was one of the most articulate sixteenth-century Anabaptists. A theologian whose learned efforts to refute the charges lodged against the Anabaptists led to his own martyrdom on 10 March 1528, Hubmaier argued

that Christians should forego violence “for the present,” but he also appears to have expected the saints to wield the righteous sword of judgment on their behalf. Yoder and Pipkin, *Balthasar Hubmaier*, 18.

19. Stanley Hauerwas, *Christian Existence Today* (Durham, NC: Labyrinth Press, 1988), 95.

20. See John H. Yoder’s “Sacrament as Social Process: Christ the Transformer of Culture,” *Theology Today* 48, 3 (Apr. 1991), 33, 41.

21. Yoder, “Sacrament as Social Process,” 41.

22. I am grateful to Ted Koontz, Richard Miller, and Terry Nardin for conversations related to this project that helped to clarify several conceptual issues. I am also grateful to John Richard Burkholder, Stanley Hauerwas, and John H. Yoder, each of whom supplied me with materials used in this chapter.